CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

SCHOOL TEACHER IN THE AI ERA

AI can grade a worksheet. It cannot hold a room of thirty kids on a rainy Friday.

★ TL;DR — Classroom teaching at a ~$67K median (composite across elementary, middle and high school), on a bachelor's plus state licence road. The honest start is lower — the national average first-year salary is $48,112 — and the pay climbs a fixed schedule from there. The catch stays the same: the degree comes before the paycheck. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

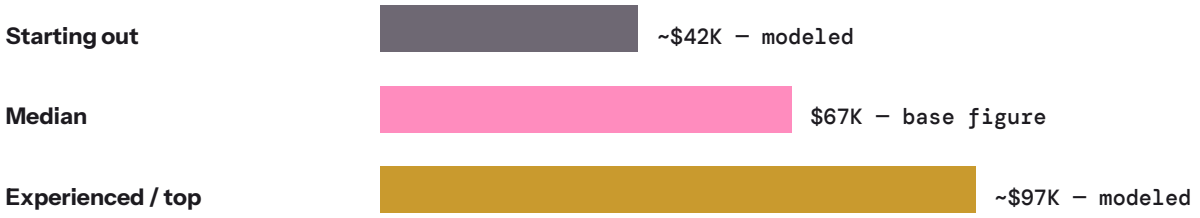
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$67K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- Correction to our old card: $45K was a starting salary, not a median. The medians are $63,820 (elementary), $64,370 (middle) and $72,040 (high school).
- Growth reads 0% — and districts still can't staff the rooms: 411,549 teaching positions are unfilled or held by teachers not fully certified for them (Learning Policy Institute).
- AI is a prep tool here, not a rival: 60% of teachers used it in 2024–25, mostly for lesson prep and worksheets; grading is among its least common uses (Gallup).

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for School Teacher is a ~$67K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A SCHOOL TEACHER ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Planning lessons and preparing materials

✓ Teaching, questioning and managing the room's behavior

✓ Grading, feedback and tracking each student's progress

✓ Parent communication, meetings and a steady flow of paperwork

Think: a live performer, coach and referee — same audience, every day, all year.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Lesson-plan drafts, worksheet generation and adapting materials to levels — Gallup's most common teacher AI uses are all preparation. Weekly users estimate saving 5.9 hours a week, reinvested in students.	The licence legally bars substitution: a public classroom must be led by a certified teacher. Presence, motivation, order and trust — live, in the room — remain the product.

⚠ **The degree-plus-licence road is years long before your first classroom paycheck, and grading follows you home in a bag. Also know the ceiling's cause: BLS blames flat growth on declining enrolment and budgets, not technology — this is a replacement-demand profession (~201,700 openings a year), so districts hire every year without the occupation 'growing'.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ A room that knows your name by October ✓ Summers, and a salary schedule you can plan on ✓ Prep tools that hand you hours back	✗ Grading follows you home ✗ Thirty daily critics, all under 18 ✗ Pay set by schedule, not by how good you are

Good fit? Patient, energetic, organized — and you genuinely like being around kids all day.
Bad fit? You're in it for the money, or you wilt when thirty people judge your performance daily.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — EDUCATION DEGREE WITH STUDENT TEACHING	DOOR B — CAREER-CHANGER ROUTE

The standard road: an accredited bachelor's with a teacher-preparation program and student teaching, then your state's exams and licence. Budget the honest numbers: you start around the $48,112 national average and climb the district schedule toward the $64–72K medians. First move: substitute-teach in your target district while you study — principals hire people they've already watched hold a room.	Already hold a bachelor's in anything? Every state runs an alternative-certification route for degree-holders — coursework plus a supervised, often paid, teaching residency (some programs are designed to finish in about a year) instead of a second degree. The catch: it presupposes the bachelor's; from zero, Door A is the road. First move: pull your state's alternative-route list and compare timelines before paying any tuition.

Smart move: Substitute-teach while you study, and choose your level with the medians in view: high school pays the most ($72,040), elementary has the most openings (~99,400 a year). Where you land after: Experienced classroom teacher, then department lead, instructional coach or an administration track.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP YOUR	ENROLL IN	COURSEWORK PLUS	STUDENT TEACHING	LICENSE EXAMS	APPLY FOR

STEP 1 — Map your state's license

FREE · TODAY

- List the exact gate: bachelor's, prep program, student teaching, exams, background check
- If you already hold a degree, price the alternative-certification route first — it can cut years

STEP 2 — Enroll in an accredited program

TUITION · YEAR 1

- Choose elementary, middle or high school — medians run $63,820 / $64,370 / $72,040
- Substitute-teach on the side: income, evidence, and a district that knows your name

STEP 3 — Coursework plus classroom time

YEARS 1–2

- Field placements in the district you want to be hired by
- Learn the prep tools — AI drafting is now a normal part of planning, not a threat to the seat

STEP 4 — Student teaching

YEAR 2–3

- A full-time classroom semester under a mentor teacher
- Build your behaviour-management record — it's what principals actually ask about

STEP 5 — License exams and application

LICENSE · FINAL YEAR

- Pass the general and subject certification exams; clear the background check
- File for the state licence at your level

STEP 6 — Apply for your classroom

FINAL MONTHS

- Apply where shortages are posted — 411,549 unfilled and under-certified seats is your negotiating context
- Negotiate step placement: prior sub and aide experience can start you above step one

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: licence requirements for your state and level, in one list.

□ Days 1–30: program (or alt-cert route) chosen; substitute-teaching application filed.

□ Days 31–60: coursework started; first sub shifts in a real classroom.

□ Days 61–90: placement school identified; exam dates on the calendar.

□ Day 90: you're inside the pipeline districts are desperate to fill — with sub days already on your record.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **PRESENCE IS THE PRODUCT.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.